

Northwind Labs Employee Handbook

Revision 7 · Effective 1 January 2099

This handbook is a high-level orientation to how we work at Northwind Labs. It summarizes our values, the way we manage time off, our working arrangements, how expenses are reimbursed, and the security expectations that apply to everyone. Where a topic has a dedicated policy, this handbook only paraphrases it; the dedicated policy document is always authoritative if the two ever disagree.

1. Working at Northwind

We are a remote-friendly company built around small, autonomous teams. Most decisions are made by the people closest to the work, with their manager's support. We value written communication, reproducible work, and treating one another with respect.

- Default to transparency: write things down so colleagues in other time zones can follow along without a meeting.
- Ask for forgiveness, not permission, on reversible decisions; ask for approval first on anything costly or hard to undo.
- Protect focus time. Core collaboration hours exist so the rest of the day is yours.

2. Time Off and Leave

Northwind offers paid time off, company holidays, sick leave, and several extended leave programs. Paid time off accrues over the year and a limited amount may roll over; the exact accrual rate, the rollover cap, and the notice you must give are defined in the Paid Time Off Policy. Extended programs such as parental, bereavement, and sabbatical leave are described in the Benefits Guide.

Requesting time off

Submit time-off requests through the people portal and give your team reasonable notice so coverage can be arranged. Emergencies are understood and the notice expectation is waived in those cases. Your manager approves the request.

3. Working Arrangements

Employees may work remotely for part of the week, subject to manager approval and the needs of the team. We keep a band of core hours so synchronous collaboration is predictable across time zones; outside those hours you manage your own schedule. When working remotely you must connect to internal systems through the company-approved VPN. The specifics · how many days, the exact core-hours window, and the approval path · live in the Remote Work Policy.

4. Expenses and Reimbursement

Reasonable business expenses are reimbursed. Travel, lodging, meals, and home-office equipment follow per-category limits and an approval threshold that scales with the amount. Keep itemized receipts and submit them promptly. The Travel and Expense Policy defines the limits, the per-diem rates, and who must approve a given amount.

5. Compensation and Benefits

Compensation is reviewed annually. Benefits include medical, dental, and vision coverage, a retirement plan with an employer match, an annual learning budget, and wellness support. Enrollment windows and the precise amounts are in the Benefits Guide.

6. Information Security

Security is everyone's responsibility. Company laptops must use full-disk encryption and lock automatically. Access to sensitive and production systems requires multi-factor authentication and is granted on a least-privilege basis. If you suspect a security incident, report it immediately through the security hotline or ticket queue. The Security Policy and the Information Security Guidelines give the full detail, including the reporting timeline and the approval required for production access.

7. Communication and Meetings

We bias toward asynchronous, written communication. Decisions, proposals, and status updates are written down and shared in the open so colleagues across time zones can catch up without a meeting. Meetings are for discussion that genuinely needs to be live; they have an agenda and a note-taker, and the notes are posted afterward.

- Keep recurring meetings inside core collaboration hours so no one is forced online outside their working day.
- Use threads, not direct messages, for anything a teammate might later need to find.
- Record important live sessions so people who could not attend are not penalized.

8. Performance and Growth

Performance is reviewed twice a year through a lightweight process focused on impact, collaboration, and growth rather than on hours logged. Your manager gives continuous feedback; the formal review simply summarizes it. Promotions follow from sustained impact at the next level and are calibrated across teams to keep the bar consistent. Your annual learning budget exists to support this growth · see the Benefits Guide.

9. Conduct and Respect

Everyone is entitled to a workplace free of harassment and discrimination. We expect professional, inclusive behavior in every channel · chat, video, documents, and in-person events alike. Concerns can be raised with your manager, the People team, or through the confidential reporting line, and they will be handled discreetly and without retaliation.

Acknowledgement

By continuing employment you acknowledge that you have read this handbook and agree to follow the policies it references. Questions go to your manager or the People team.